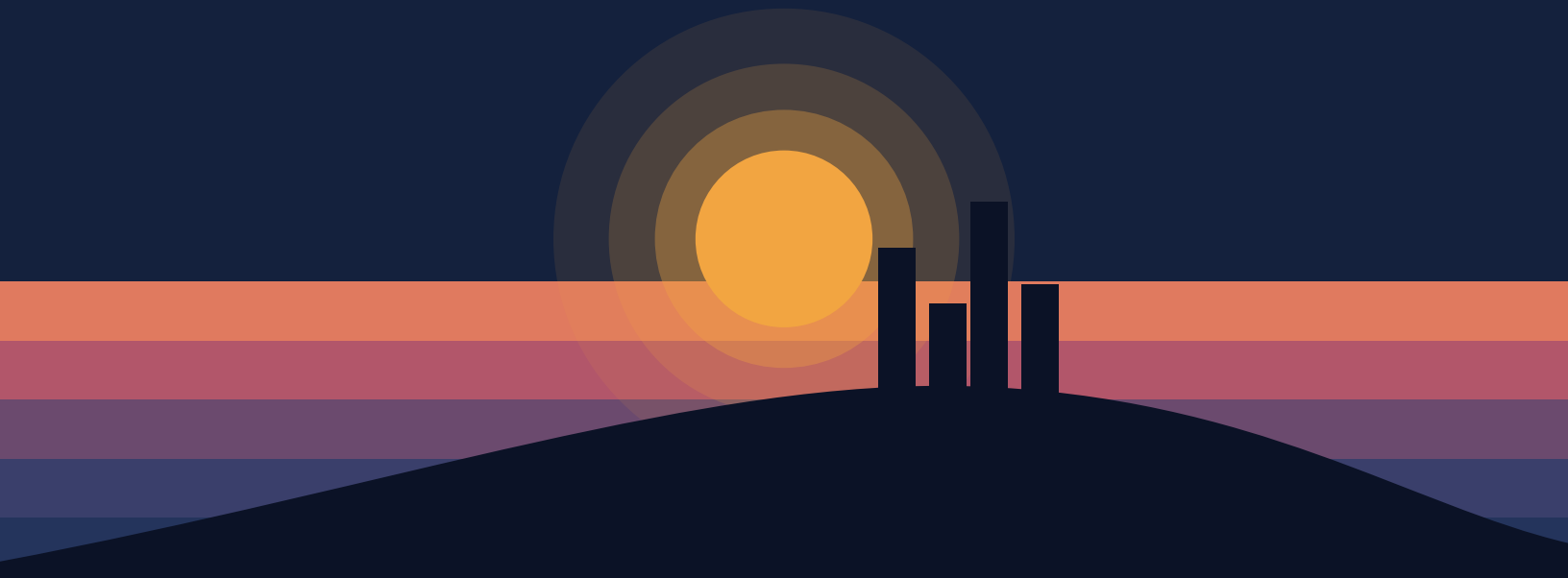
THE WOLF OF McKENZIE TOWNE • SEASON ONE

LORE & HISTORY

A briefing for telling the story with confidence

“The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it.”



[TRUE] = documented history
[LEGEND] = centuries-old folklore
[OUR LORE] = invented for the event

Speaker briefing • October 2026

How to Use This Briefing

The story mixes **real history** with **invented lore**. Being able to tell them apart is what will make you sound confident. Throughout this document:

- **[TRUE] TRUE** marks real, documented history. You can say these as fact.
- **[LEGEND] LEGEND** marks folklore that real people have told for centuries. Introduce it with "the legend says…"
- **[OUR LORE] OUR LORE** marks what we invented for the event. Tell it with a wink.

If you only have five minutes, read **Part 1** and **Part 7**.

PART 1

The Story in 30 Seconds and in 2 Minutes

The 30-second version

> *"McKenzie Towne's streets are named after Scottish towns: Elgin, Inverness and Prestwick. In 1390, a real Scottish rogue called the Wolf of Badenoch burned Elgin Cathedral, which was nicknamed the Lantern of the North. In our story, the Wolf is back. He has stolen the Lantern again and scattered its shards across our parks. Clans of teens have until dusk to recover them, outrun the Wolf's pack on Elgin Hill, and relight the Lantern while the whole neighbourhood turns on its porch lights."*

The 2-minute version

> *"When McKenzie Towne was planned in the 1990s, it was designed to feel like a village, and its neighbourhoods took the names of real Scottish towns. Each of those towns has a remarkable story.*
>
> ***Elgin** had one of the most beautiful cathedrals in Scotland, called the Lantern of the North. In 1390, Alexander Stewart, a king's son better known as the Wolf of Badenoch, burned it to the ground in a feud with the local bishop. Here's the part people don't expect: he was later made to do public penance, he was forgiven, and he helped pay to rebuild it.*
>
> ***Inverness** is where, around the year 565, St. Columba is said to have faced a monster in the River Ness. That's the oldest written root of the Loch Ness legend.*
>
> ***Prestwick** hosted the very first Open Championship in golf, in 1860.*
>
> *Our event borrows all of it. The Wolf has stolen the Lantern again. A ridiculous, kilted, 347-year-old Laird sends clans of teens across the Towne to recover the shards: fighting fires, cracking vaults, jousting dragons and fishing for Nessie's eggs. At dusk they relight the Lantern, and the whole neighbourhood turns on its porch lights. It's a story about light coming back to a community, and it's carried by our youth."*

PART 2

The Real History

2.1 Elgin Cathedral: "The Lantern of the North" [TRUE]

- **Where:** Elgin, in Moray, northeast Scotland.
- **Founded:** 1224, when the seat of the Bishop of Moray moved to Elgin.
- **Reputation:** one of the largest and most beautiful cathedrals in medieval Scotland, traditionally nicknamed the **"Lantern of the North."** (Historians aren't certain who first coined the phrase. If anyone asks, say "it's been known as the Lantern of the North for centuries.")
- **The fire:** in **1390**, the cathedral, along with much of the town of Elgin, was burned by Alexander Stewart, the Wolf of Badenoch.
- **The rebuilding:** it was rebuilt. Later bishops set aside **a third of their yearly income** until the work was finished, and the Wolf himself contributed to the cost.
- **The long decline:** after the Scottish Reformation (1560), the cathedral fell out of use. The lead was stripped from its roof in the 1560s, and its great central tower collapsed in **1711**.
- **Today:** a magnificent roofless ruin, cared for by Historic Environment Scotland and still visited by thousands.

Why it matters for us: the castle-style "ruins" on top of **Elgin Hill** in McKenzie Towne become, in our story, the Lantern's original home. The race ends where the legend began.

2.2 The Wolf of Badenoch [TRUE]

- **Real name: Alexander Stewart**, Earl of Buchan (1343 to about 1405).
- **Royal blood:** a son of **King Robert II** of Scotland, and brother of King Robert III.
- **Why "Wolf":** he ruled the wild Badenoch region of the Highlands by force and fear. The nickname came from his reputation.
- **The feud:** his marriage was unhappy and he was openly unfaithful. His wife turned to **Bishop Alexander Bur** of Moray, who sided with her, and the bishop **excommunicated** him.
- **The revenge:** in **June 1390**, he and his followers burned the town of Forres, then **Elgin**, including the cathedral.
- **The surprising ending:** he was made to do **public penance**. He was pardoned, his excommunication was lifted, and he contributed to rebuilding the cathedral.
- **His tomb:** in **Dunkeld Cathedral**, where his armoured stone effigy can still be seen. It is one of the few medieval Scottish royal monuments to survive.

The talking point: *"Even the Wolf was forgiven, and he helped rebuild what he burned."* It's a redemption story, and it leaves room for the Wolf's own story arc in future seasons.

2.3 Inverness, St. Columba and the first "Nessie" [TRUE] + [LEGEND]

- **Who: St. Columba** (521–597), the Irish monk who founded the monastery on the island of Iona and brought Christianity to much of northern Scotland.
- **The source:** the *Life of St. Columba*, written by **Adomnán**, abbot of Iona, around **AD 700**.

- **The story:** while travelling to meet the Pictish king near Inverness, Columba came to the **River Ness**. A "water beast" rose to attack one of his companions. Columba made the **sign of the cross** and commanded it: *"Go no further, nor touch the man. Go back with all speed!"* The beast fled.
- **Why it matters:** it's the **oldest written account** behind the Loch Ness Monster legend. The modern "Nessie" craze began much later, in 1933.

Why it matters for us: it's why the Gazebo Tribunal's Roadblock clue asks, *"Who has a voice that can wake a loch monster?"*, and why Nessie's eggs turn up at the pond.

2.4 Prestwick and the birth of championship golf [TRUE]

- **Where:** Prestwick, on Scotland's west coast.
- **What:** the **first Open Championship** was played at Prestwick Golf Club on **17 October 1860**. Eight professionals played three rounds of the 12-hole course in a single day.
- **The winner:** Willie Park Sr.
- **The prize:** not a trophy but a **red leather Challenge Belt**. When **Young Tom Morris** won it three times in a row (1868–70), he kept it for good. The famous **Claret Jug** was first awarded in 1872.

Why it matters for us: a nod for the golf trick-shot option at the Pirate & Castle Park station, and a good fact for any golfers in the room.

2.5 Calgary's own Scottish roots [TRUE]

- **The city's name is Scottish.** In **1876**, Colonel James Macleod of the North-West Mounted Police named Fort Calgary after **Calgary Bay on the Isle of Mull**, in Scotland.
- **The Sandstone City:** after the **Great Fire of 1886** destroyed much of Calgary's wooden downtown, the city rebuilt in local Paskapoo sandstone, which earned it the nickname *"Sandstone City."* That's the Firetruck Park link: a city that was rebuilt after a fire, just as Elgin was.
- **Scots in the West:** Scottish fur traders, surveyors and settlers shaped much of early Western Canada. Many Hudson's Bay Company men came from Orkney and the Highlands. That's the inspiration for our Laird, who claims to have "come west with the fur traders."

2.6 McKenzie Towne itself [TRUE]

- **Planned:** construction began in **1995** by Carma Developers (now Brookfield Residential).
- **Design:** one of Canada's early **New Urbanist** communities. The design firm Duany Plater-Zyberk, known for walkable "village" planning, was brought in. The goal was the feel of an old town: front porches, rear lanes, small squares and a walkable **High Street**.
- **Recognition:** the Urban Land Institute named it among the world's top master-planned communities.
- **Scottish naming:** its neighbourhoods carry Scottish town names (Elgin, Inverness, Prestwick), and its streets have names like Promenade and High Street.
- **The themed parks:** McKenzie Towne's playgrounds were built as **themed play worlds**: a fire truck with a pretend town, a pirate ship and a castle, a dragon's castle with a hidden dinosaur skeleton, a ship by the pond, and castle ruins on Elgin Hill.

The key insight: *we didn't impose a story on McKenzie Towne. The story was already in the street names and the parks. We just connected the dots.*

PART 3

The Legends [LEGEND]

3.1 The Wolf's last game of chess

The most famous legend about the Wolf: on a stormy night in July 1394, a tall stranger dressed in black arrived at Ruthven Castle and challenged him to a game of chess. As the game ended, the stranger said "Check," and then "Mate," and a terrible thunderstorm broke over the castle. By morning the stranger was gone. The Wolf's men lay dead outside the walls, and the Wolf himself was found in the great hall, unmarked except that the nails had been torn from his boots. People said the stranger was the Devil himself.

(Historians treat this as legend. The real Wolf most likely died around 1405.)

How to use it: this is our explanation for how the Wolf "returned." Because no one is sure how or when he died, the legend says he never truly left.

3.2 Nessie

From Columba's beast to the 1933 sightings to today, the Loch Ness Monster is Scotland's most famous legend. In our lore, Nessie is shy, harmless and **guarding her eggs**, and one of those eggs is Season Two's cliffhanger.

PART 4

Our Lore: the World of the Race [OUR LORE]

4.1 The premise

For centuries, the **Lantern of the North** has quietly watched over McKenzie Towne, which is (says the Laird) "a wee piece of Scotland on the prairie." Its light is why neighbours wave, why porch lights glow, and why the Towne feels like a village.

Then the **Wolf** returns. Unforgiven in his own mind, and still smarting from that chess game, he steals the Lantern and shatters it into **five shards**, scattered across the Towne's parks. Without the Lantern, the Towne will go dark at dusk.

The **Laird** summons the clans: only the young, he insists, can carry the light now.

4.2 The characters

Character	Who they are	Personality	Signature line
Laird Lachlan McKenzie	Self-proclaimed founder of the Towne. Claims to be **347 years old** (born 1680 in Inverness, "came west with the fur traders").	Pompous, kind-hearted, sentimental, deeply afraid of geese. Plays a Bluetooth bagpipe.	*"Clan ___, ye have arrived. Ye are… the FIRST clan!"*
The Wolf	The spirit (or heir; he won't say) of Alexander Stewart, the Wolf of Badenoch.	Smug and theatrical. **Never speaks**; communicates through recordings and wax-sealed notes.	*"I burned it once in 1390. I'll hide it forever now."*
The Wolf Pack	The Wolf's hooded followers.	Silent, cloaked, red glow belts. Fierce but fair (flags only!).	*(growling, optional)*
Dodgy Dougal	The Wolf's sloppy accomplice, found at the Firetruck Park donut shop.	Nervous and chatty. Talks only to someone eating a donut on a string with no hands.	*"I didnae see nothin'!"*
The Dragon	Guardian of the Elgin Dragon Playground.	Proud. Duels with pool noodles.	—
The Gazebo Tribunal	Three wigged judges at Inverness Square.	Stern, dramatic, secretly soft-hearted.	*"The Tribunal is… unmoved."*
Nessie	Shy guardian of the eggs.	Seen only from a distance.	—

4.3 The five shards and where they're hidden

Shard	Park	Why it's there (in the story)	The real-world link
1	**Firetruck Park**	The Wolf burned the cathedral, so the first shard is where the fire is fought. Hidden in the bank vault, guarded by Dodgy Dougal.	Elgin's 1390 fire; Calgary's 1886 fire
2	**Pirate & Castle Park**	Plundered and hidden aboard the pirate ship, or locked in the castle.	Scotland's castles and sea raiders; the Prestwick golf nod
3	**Elgin Ship Playground** (by Inverness Pond)	Nessie wrecked the Wolf's getaway ship. The shard sank among her eggs.	St. Columba and the River Ness beast
4	**Elgin Dragon Playground**	The Wolf bribed the Dragon to guard it.	Medieval castles; the hidden dinosaur skeleton ("even dragons had grandfathers")
5	**Elgin Hill Ruins**	The Lantern's original home, guarded by the Wolf himself.	The ruins of the real Elgin Cathedral

Along the way: the **Merchant's Dare** on High Street (Scottish accents required), the **Gazebo Tribunal** at Inverness Square, and the **Laird's Haggis Banquet** at Promenade Park.

4.4 The finale: Relight the Lantern

At dusk the clans bring the five shards together, the giant Lantern blazes back to life, and **every neighbour switches on their porch light**, a sign that the light belongs to the whole Towne.

4.5 The cliffhanger: Season Two

As the celebration fades, the screen flickers one last time. The Wolf stands on the deck of the pirate ship, holding a **cracked, glowing Nessie egg**. *"Season Two. The egg hatches."*

Possible arcs for future seasons:

- **The Egg:** what hatches, and whose side is it on?
- **The Wolf's redemption:** like the real Wolf, does he eventually do penance and help rebuild?
- **The Laird's secret:** is he really 347?

PART 5

The Themes (Why the Story Matters)

Theme	In the story	What to say
Light returning	The Lantern is relit, and porch lights come on across the Towne.	"It's a story about bringing light back into a community."
Youth carrying the light	The Laird trusts the young to restore it.	"We're showing our teens that the community trusts them to lead."
Neighbours belonging to each other	The light belongs to every porch, not one person.	"The finale only works if neighbours join in."
Redemption	The real Wolf was forgiven and helped rebuild.	"Even the villain's real story ends with forgiveness and rebuilding."
Place and roots	Our street names carry real history.	"Our neighbourhood already had a story. We just told it."

Scripture woven through the event materials (quoted without references):

- *"Let your light shine before others."* The Lantern.
- *"Let no one despise you for your youth."* Youth leadership.
- *"Two are better than one… if they fall, the one will lift up his fellow."* The clans.
- *"Let us run with patience the race that is set before us."* The race.

PART 6

Pronunciation Guide

Word	Say it	What it is
Badenoch	*BAD-en-ock* (soft "ch," as in *loch*)	The Wolf's Highland territory
Moray	*MUR-ee*	The region where Elgin sits
Elgin	*EL-gin* (hard "g")	The cathedral town
Inverness	*in-ver-NESS*	Capital of the Highlands
Columba	*co-LUM-ba*	The 6th-century monk
Adomnán	*AD-om-nawn*	Columba's biographer
Ruthven	*RIV-en*	The castle in the chess legend
Dunkeld	*dun-KELD*	Where the Wolf is buried
Lachlan	*LOCH-lan*	The Laird's first name
Laird	*LAIRD* (rhymes with "cared")	A Scottish landowner
Ceilidh	*KAY-lee*	A Scottish party with music and dancing (a possible Season Two finale!)
Sporran	*SPOR-an*	The pouch worn with a kilt

PART 7

Quick Facts and Likely Questions

Ten facts to have ready

1. Elgin Cathedral was founded in **1224** and burned in **1390**.
2. The Wolf of Badenoch was **Alexander Stewart**, son of **King Robert II**.
3. He did **public penance**, was forgiven, and **helped pay to rebuild** the cathedral.
4. His tomb, with his armoured effigy, is in **Dunkeld Cathedral**.
5. The oldest written root of the **Loch Ness Monster** is St. Columba's story, written about **AD 700**.
6. The first **Open Championship** was played at **Prestwick** on **17 October 1860**, for a leather belt.
7. **Calgary is named after Calgary Bay on the Isle of Mull**, Scotland (1876).
8. After the **1886 fire**, Calgary rebuilt in sandstone and became the "Sandstone City."
9. **McKenzie Towne** broke ground in **1995** as one of Canada's early New Urbanist villages.
10. Its playgrounds were **built as themed worlds**: fire truck, pirate ship, castle, dragon, ship and ruins.

Questions you may be asked

"Is this scary for kids?" "It's spooky-fun, not scary. Think of it as an adventure movie for PG audiences. The 'chase' happens only on a coned, lit part of Elgin Hill, with flag belts and marshals. Younger kids get their own gentle afternoon quest."

"Is it a religious event?" "It's a community event for everyone. The real history includes a cathedral and a saint, and the themes of light, redemption and neighbourliness come from that heritage. Families of any background are welcome."

"Why make a villain out of a real person?" "Because his real story has a great ending: he was forgiven and helped rebuild. We keep it playful, and the Wolf is a character, not a caricature."

"Why Scottish?" "Because McKenzie Towne already is. It's in our street names, and even Calgary's own name comes from Scotland. We didn't invent the theme; we found it."

"Is the Laird real?" *(Smile.)* "He'd be offended you asked."

"What happens next year?" "The Wolf escaped with a Nessie egg. You'll have to come back to find out what hatches."

PART 8

Fact Check: What to Say Carefully

Claim	Status	Safe wording
"The Lantern of the North" nickname	Traditional; origin uncertain	"It has long been known as the Lantern of the North."
The Wolf's death in 1394 after a chess game with the Devil	Legend	"Legend says…" (historians suggest he died around 1405)
The stone arch or ruins on Elgin Hill	Their origin isn't confirmed	"The ruins on Elgin Hill" (don't claim where they came from)
Laird Lachlan's age, history and fear of geese	Our invention	Tell it with a wink
The Wolf "returning"	Our invention	"In our story…"

Sources

- Aberdeenshire Historic Environment Record: Elgin Cathedral
- Undiscovered Scotland: Alexander Bur
- Undiscovered Scotland: Alexander Stewart, Earl of Buchan
- Press and Journal: Elgin Cathedral history
- Elgin Museum: Elgin Cathedral art exhibition (PDF)
- Edinburgh Evening News: Wolf of Badenoch dies after chess game with devil (legend)
- Wikipedia: Dunkeld Cathedral
- Wikipedia: McKenzie Towne, Calgary
- Congress for the New Urbanism: McKenzie Towne scales back TND plan
- City of Calgary: City Hall sandstone heritage
- McKenzie Towne Council: Parks & Ponds
- Calgary Playground Review: Prestwick Pirate & Castle Park, Firetruck Park, Elgin Dragon Playground

Some details are drawn from general historical knowledge: Adomnán's Life of St. Columba*, the history of the Open Championship, and the naming of Fort Calgary. They're well documented and easy to check in any standard reference.*